Targeted Issue Advertising and Legislative Strategy: The Inside Ends of Outside Lobbying

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Interest group spending on issue advertising is growing dramatically, but we know very little about its deployment and purpose in legislative advocacy. This article begins to fill the gap, examining where, when, and why interest groups run television issue advertisements. We start from the premise that issue advertising is a form of outside lobbying, but we argue that it can serve two legislative ends. We hypothesize, first, that group strategists will target areas represented by committee allies they want to mobilize more than pivotal members they want to convert. When a roll call is approaching and the vote is likely to be close, however, groups will expand their advertising targets to include floor voters near the chamber pivot. Our statistical tests use data on television issue ads concerning the 2003 Medicare prescription drug bill. The analysis provides consistent support for the first hypothesis and mixed support for the second.

As the first anniversary of his election drew near, President Bill Clinton seemed poised to succeed on the most ambitious domestic policy initiative in a quarter century, Congress and the American public on his side. The bill was the administration's proposal for national health care reform. A year later it lay dead on a Democratic Congress's floor. A multitude of reasons have been given for this outcome, but prominent in the immediate postmortems were the advertising campaigns of opposition groups. "Harry and Louise" had become household names representing the allegedly high costs of the Clinton plan and the supposedly serious limits it would place on individual choice. Journalists and politicians at the time asserted that the insurance industry's campaign killed health care reform. We now know that those claims were overstated (Jacobs 2001; Jacobs and Shapiro 1994), but the idea that "Harry and Louise" subverted reform by manipulating a gullible public underlined important questions about the changing practice of American democracy.[1]

Four presidential terms later, such worries have hardly abated. Quite the reverse. Issue advertising has grown dramatically as an instrument of interest group advocacy, enlarging the already substantial role that money plays in American politics. One estimate put spending on issue advertisements in the 108th Congress in the DC media market alone at over $400 million dollars (Falk, Grizard, and McDonald 2006). Back on the agenda in 2009, health care reform generated issue advertising that saturated the airwaves, including ads by the original Harry and Louise (this time playing pro-reform roles). Other areas, such as energy, environmental, and economic policy, have generated major advertising campaigns as well. While no precise data are available, interest groups easily spent more on issue-related advertising during 2009–10 than they gave in campaign contributions to all candidates in the midterm congressional elections of 2009–10 combined.[2]

However conspicuous its growth, issue advertising has generated little systematic research. The literature on PACs, for instance, is vast, spanning half a dozen disciplines with publications on the subject in several

[1]Data and supporting materials necessary to reproduce the numerical results in this article will be made available at (http://www-personal.umich.edu/~rickhall/) on publication of this article. Ancillary analyses referred to in the text can be found in the online appendix at http://journals.cambridge.org/jop.

[2]PACs contributed less than $500 million to congressional candidates in the 2009–10 cycle; television issue ads on health care reform alone amounted to half that amount (Scherer 2010).

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dozen journals. Research on inside lobbying likewise has a long tradition, and the last two decades have produced a literature rich in quantity and theoretical quality (see e.g., Baumgartner et al. 2009; Grossman and Helpman 2001; Wright 1996). By comparison, the research on issue advertising is limited to a few specific aspects of the phenomenon. Several studies have examined the effects of issue advertising on public opinion (e.g., Groenendyk and Valentino 2002; Jamieson 2000; Valentino, Hutchings, and Williams 2004), and two major studies examine issue advertising inside the Washington beltway (Falk 2003; Falk, Grizard, and McDonald 2006). Bergan (2009) examines the legislative effects of email campaigns, which are different in cost and theoretical kind from advertising. In short, research on the use of advertising in legislative advocacy has barely begun, almost two decades after the original Harry and Louise receded into our television screens.[3]

This article provides the first systematic attempt to fill that gap, examining where, when, and why interest groups target their television issue advertising. Empirically, we focus on televised issue advertisements, the objective of which is to influence legislators by mobilizing constituents to contact them. Theoretically, we build from two simple premises: first, that issue advertising is a particular form of "outside" lobbying (Goldstein 1999; Jamieson 2000) and, second, that outside lobbying is an instrument for achieving inside, legislative ends (Goldstein 1999; Hansen 1991; Kollman 1998). Understanding strategies on the outside, in other words, requires a theory of lobbying on the inside. What are the proximate political objectives that govern a group's inside lobbying? How do group strategists map those inside objectives into outside strategies? With respect to issue advertising, more specifically, at whom will groups target their advertising buys, given that their immediate legislative objectives can change as a bill moves through the multistage legislative process?

In addressing these questions, we reexamine the inside goals that outside lobbying serves. Past scholarship has focused on how signals from a grassroots constituency can influence swing members' preferences over policies, hence their roll-call votes. We hypothesize that issue advertising will more heavily target key legislative allies, its purpose being not to change their positions, but to motivate their participation on an issue about which the interest group cares. When a roll call is forthcoming and likely to be close, however, the focus of groups may change, and the allocation of issue ads should expand to include legislators near the chamber pivot. We evaluate these hypotheses using data on televised advertisements concerning the Medicare Prescription Drug, Improvement, and Modernization Act of 2003 (hereafter, MMA), one of the most important domestic programs of the George W. Bush presidency.

The Inside Ends of Outside Lobbying

Any theory of issue advertising must answer two questions that the interest group strategist implicitly confronts: What ends will it serve? And through what mechanisms does it work?

Our account begins from the premise that outside lobbying is a means to a group's inside, legislative ends (Goldstein 1999, 75–78; Hansen 1991; Kollman 1998).[4] A theory of outside advertising thus requires a theory of inside lobbying. The literature on inside lobbying, in turn, emphasizes two different assumptions whose implications only partly overlap. The most prominent view holds that lobbying is primarily about changing legislators' preferences over policies, specifically, to win the votes of undecided legislators when a bill comes to the floor (e.g., Austen-Smith and Wright 1994; Rothenberg 1992; Wright 1996). Lobbying resources, whether financial or informational, will be deployed to this purpose.

A second view holds that lobbying is more about influencing members' legislative effort than their votes. According to this view, inside lobbyists primarily lobby group-friendly members they want to mobilize and assist. Matthews long ago (1960) labeled this mechanism "backstopping." Ainsworth (1997) suggests that "lobbying enterprises" now serve this purpose. Hall and Deardorff (2006) argue that inside lobbying "subsidizes" the information costs and staff time associated with legislative effort, enabling their allies to promote policies important to the group at a lower cost.

Kollman's (1998) and Goldstein's (1999) accounts of outside lobbying rely primarily on the first view of inside lobbying. In mounting outside lobbying efforts, Kollman argues, interest groups "use precious resources...to convince policymakers to change their minds about something" (1998, 59). This process of opinion change works simultaneously through two constituency-centered mechanisms: signaling the

[3]See Goldstein (2001) and Loomis and Sexton (1995) for two insightful exceptions.

[4]Some groups run ads intended to enhance an organization's membership, reputation, or goodwill or otherwise promote organizational maintenance. Our analysis screened such ads unless they also contained an advocacy message regarding the MMA.

direction and salience of constituency opinion and expanding the scope of conflict by increasing that salience. Information about direction affects the legislator's perceptions about whether her positions are out of step with her constituents. Information about salience affects legislator expectations about the weight that constituents will give her issue position when voting in the next election (Goldstein 1999, 42–51; Kollman 1998, 68–72). By generating mail and other constituency contacts, grassroots campaigns affect those weights, altering the calculations of legislators about the connections between the policies they support and their probability of reelection. Thus does Kollman argue that significant outside activity can "make an offending policymaker uncomfortable in the next election" (1998, 22).

Kollman's quantity of interest is the issues on which groups will choose to outside lobby, however, not the members they will target once they do. Nonetheless, his theory has implications regarding the member-specific targeting of issue advertising. Assuming that popularity and salience vary not only by issue (as Kollman posits), but also by geography, two hypotheses follow: groups will concentrate their advertising in states and districts (1) where the issue of interest is (potentially) salient, and (2) where their position on the issue is (latently) popular.

That outside lobbying is intended to induce wavering members to support the group's position is more central in Goldstein's account: "Grassroots communications signal a legislator that a particular issue is on the radar screen and that constituents are paying attention to his or her action," he argues, adding that such communications reduce the uncertainty regarding how the legislator's actions could be used against her in the next election (1999, 39). The decisions at issue are the positions that legislators take. To be good targets, they need to be "persuadable," their votes thus changeable. "With grassroots tactics being used in pursuit of a legislative objective, it is the middle that matters," he summarizes, "Lobbyists should target undecided legislators" (46). Swing members on the committees of jurisdiction, Goldstein argues, warrant special attention (58–59).

We extend Kollman (1998) and Goldstein (1999) to incorporate the second view of inside lobbying, which emphasizes the importance of mobilizing one's legislative allies, and trace its implications for outside advertising. Outside lobbying is an instrument for influencing legislators' constituency-induced preferences, inherently so in our view, but the outside mechanisms that Kollman and Goldstein identify can serve more than one behavioral end. Hall and Deardorff raise this point in discussing the limitations of their model of inside lobbying (2006). By providing information to friendly members and supplementing their staff capacity, a group subsidizes the *ability* of those members to work effectively on a policy objective they share with a group.[5] But it does not affect their *willingness* to do so. Subsidies enable, they do not motivate. Outside lobbying is the complementary mechanism: by increasing the salience of a policy among sympathetic constituents, a group increases the incentives for its legislative allies to work on that issue.[6] To put the point in Mayhew's terms (1974, 52–53, 60–61), legislators engage in specialized legislative work insofar as it helps them make credible claims of credit for policies about which their constituents care. Issue advertising is an attempt to make those constituents care or, at least, make legislators think that their constituents care. To put the point in Sulkin's terms (2005), issue advertising between elections can do what challengers' campaigns do during them (Anderson 2009). It induces legislators to shift their "issue attention" toward new priorities, not change their issue positions.

Not all allies are equally efficient at promoting the legislative goals they share with the group, however. Denzau and Munger (1986) argue that interest groups will seek to mobilize allies for whom the "productivity" of their effort is high, namely, members with positions on the committees of jurisdiction. Committee allies carry water for the cause, shaping the legislation, striking bargains, gaining cosponsors, or executing obstruction. Indeed, committee allies play important roles beyond the committee stage as strategists, coalition builders, and cue givers, such that mobilizing committee allies is important to the interest group even at the roll call stage when the majority works its will.

Hall and Deardorff (2006) suggest that issue advertising might also be used to demobilize a group's already committed opponents by creating cross-pressure among their constituents. In principle, an increase in critical mail might induce opponents to curtail their involvement, diminishing visibility so that they might avoid blame (Goldstein 1999).[7] In

[5]In Hall and Deardorff's terms, it shifts the member's budget line out but leaves her willingness-to-pay unchanged (2006, 78, Figure 4)

[6]In Hall and Deardorff's terms, it leaves the member's legislative resources unchanged, but it shifts the tangency of the indifference curve down the budget line, increasing the legislative resources she invests in promoting the policy objective she shares with the group (2006, Figure 3).

[7]The term is Arnold's (1990), but Goldstein (1999) emphasizes its importance for outside lobbying.

practice, we think issue advertising as a demobilization strategy has limited potential, however. The main reason is that the conditions that make outside lobbying likely to occur—constituency salience and support for the group's position—make it less likely that a member will oppose the group in the first place, much less do so actively. A second reason is that television advertising used to undermine members back in their districts carries significant downside risks. The member who believes a policy to be good for her district may view critical ads as attempts to "manipulate" her constituents (Kollman 1998, 23–24). If, contrary to its aspirations, an ad campaign incites little constituent pressure, that too may hurt the interest group's cause. "Policymakers are most impressed," Kollman argues, "by large-scale grassroots activities spawned by low-cost interest group mobilizations" (1998, 104, see also 74–76). If a meager constituency reaction should follow a costly advertising campaign, in contrast, the member should infer the opposite of what the group wanted: either the issue is not salient or the group's position is not popular. As a result, the member will feel *less* cross-pressure, not more.

Finally, we reconsider Goldstein's argument about the importance of electoral vulnerability in choosing legislative targets. Such members, he argues, will be more responsive to constituency pressure, making them more "persuadable" in the face of a grassroots campaign. We agree but think the behavioral effect more general. Vulnerable members will also tend to be more "mobilizable." Again Mayhew provides the basic logic: single-minded seekers of reelection "relentlessly" seek opportunities for credit claiming (1974, 52–61), but claims of legislative credit will prove most valuable on issues to which constituents are paying attention.

Issue Advertising in Legislative Stages

If outside lobbying is driven by inside strategy, outside targets should change as inside objectives change, and those objectives can change as a bill moves through a multistage process (Kollman 1999, 105–111). Even after a bill is reported, committee leaders remain important as agenda setters and cue givers. If winning votes is the interest group's proximate goal, it may be well-served by lobbying indirectly, a process by which a group enables or induces legislative allies to spend political capital on wavering colleagues (Hojnacki and Kimball 1999).

Even so, the floor stage expands the scope of conflict to a wider set of members. Attention shifts from the activities of committee members to the preferences of the pivotal rank and file. Outside lobbying, by generating phone calls and mail, has the potential to affect the legislator's perceptions of those preferences (see esp. Miler 2010). The media consultants that run advertising campaigns also track constituency responses, providing private information that the lobbyist can use to pull members over to the interest group's side (Austen-Smith and Wright 1994, 29)

In the Medicare prescription drug debate, for example, it became clear early in the process that multiple roll calls would occur on the floor in both chambers. Pro-bill leaders in the Senate had to fend off scores of amendments during midsummer floor consideration. On the House side, the floor votes on initial passage and adoption of the conference report could not have been closer. The bill passed by a single vote in June of 2003, and a surprising number of votes on motions to instruct conferees were held in late summer and fall while the conference was in action, some of them quite close. The House vote on the conference report in November was kept open for an unprecedented three hours because the bill managers initially fell short. In sum, this case should provide a relatively difficult test of our hypothesis that issue advertising is more often a strategy for mobilizing allies than pressuring members in the middle, but it also allows us to test for the stage-specific importance of the latter.

To summarize, issue advertising can serve either of two legislative ends: persuading wavering legislators or mobilizing key supporters, but the latter objective should prove important throughout the process. Persuading pivotal members becomes the proximate inside objective when roll calls are forthcoming and likely to be close, conditions that do not always hold.

From Strategic Targets to Advertising Buys

Hypotheses about the inside value of targeting particular legislators do not translate neatly into hypotheses about geographically distributed advertising buys, however. Were there a one-to-one correspondence between a single member's electorate and a single media market, the mapping would be unproblematic, but that is not the case. Most media markets (and stations within those markets) include viewers in multiple states and districts. Moreover, the structure of representation in Congress insures that every advertisement necessarily reaches the electorates of three or more legislators. Every senator's geographic electorate overlaps the electorate of her state colleague perfectly, and

both senators represent the electorate of each House member in the state's delegation.

Issue advertising buys thus require the strategist to solve a series of complex mapping problems—how to map the electoral geography of more or less valuable legislative targets, on the one hand, to television market geography on the other. The lobbyist's principal inside targets will drive the outside strategy, we assume, but the efficiency-minded advertising buyer will also want to consider the (variable) targeting value of other members that share a given media market. This is especially true of generic ads, that is, ads that incite the viewer to contact their representative(s) without identifying members by name.[8] Insofar as viewers do not recognize the name of their own representative(s), in fact, the targeting value of legislators that share a media market should affect the allocation of member-specific ads as well.

That said, state boundaries will almost always structure these mapping decisions. When only the Senate is in legislative play, states necessarily define the areas that a group will target with its advertising buys. When both Senate and House are in play, as in the case we analyze here, the ad buys we observe will be structured partly by the upper chamber's state-level geography and partly by the location of targeted House members' districts. Those districts are not randomly distributed geographically, however. They are nested within states, their representatives within state delegations. State boundaries thus simplify the strategist's mapping decisions.

In analyzing advertising buys, we thus assume that the state level approximates the level at which advertising strategists make their allocation decisions.[9] The main dependent variable in the analysis to come, then, is the number of ads run by group j in state i. Our main tests about targeting, in turn, will be tests about the composition of state congressional delegations. We also, however, conduct district-level tests for the United Seniors Association, the only group whose ads targeted specific House members. This district-level analysis will thus provide a focused if partial check of our delegation-level results against the possibility of aggregation bias.

The Data: Issue Advertising on the Medicare Prescription Drug Bill

To execute the tests identified above, we use data on the location and frequency of ads regarding the Medicare prescription drug bill collected by the Wisconsin Advertising Project. For the congress under study here (the 108th), the Wisconsin Project catalogued political television ads in the top 100 media markets, with codes for sponsor, content, incidence, date, and media market. We screened the advertisement storyboards for all issue ads, January through November 2003, that mentioned Medicare and prescription drugs.[10] Five groups ran advertising campaigns related to the bill: AARP; Alliance for Retired Americans (ARA); Alliance to Improve Medicare (AIM); Pfizer, Inc.; and United Seniors Association (USA). All but ARA supported the bill, though AARP did not officially endorse the Bush Administration bill until after the conference committee reported the final version.[11]

As we anticipate above, the main measurement problem (for the media strategist and for us) is how to map congressional geography, defined by state boundaries (and districts nested within states) into the geography of broadcast advertising, defined in the data by media market (DMA) boundaries. For DMAs that encompass households in only one state (e.g., the Des Moines DMA), the assignment of ads to states was straightforward. If an ad appeared on a station with a multistate DMA, however, we counted it as an ad that ran in each state. The Philadelphia media market, for example, reaches substantial audiences in Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and Delaware. An issue ad appearing in the Philadelphia media market, then, would have been seen by large portions of viewers in all three states and thus counted in the total for each. We use a similar procedure for assigning ads to House districts for the analysis of the United Seniors Association data, which we discuss below. Finally, we

[8]Most ads are generic. Only one of the five organizations in our analysis ran any member-specific ads, though generic ads often provide a toll-free number or link that then connects viewers to their legislators.

[9]The media-market level is less defensible in that it assumes that interest group strategists think in terms of "DMA delegations" and "DMA-constituencies." It also creates more difficult aggregation problems, for the strategist and the researcher. We nonetheless conducted a DMA-level analysis as a robustness check, the results of which we report in an online appendix. The constituency effects proved weaker, but advertisers clearly favored DMAs represented by allies more than swing voters.

[10]Falk, Grizard, and McDonald (2006, 152–54) discuss the complications of coding both print and broadcast issue ads in the DC area. Few of the problems they identify arose in our coding of MMA television ads, which included only a few dozen distinct storyboards.

[11]AARP pushed for a more generous package than the Administration proposed, but none of its ads distinguished between alternative plans. Critics asserted that AARP supported the White House bill because of the insurance revenues it would generate for the organization (see Freudenheim 2003).

calculated separately the incidence of state ads during four legislative stages that followed almost identical schedules in the two chambers: (1) The beginning of the congress until the committees in the respective chambers completed their markups in mid-June 2003. In the Senate, the committees with jurisdiction were Finance and Health, Employment, Labor, and Pensions (HELP); in the House, they were Ways and Means and Energy and Commerce. (2) The two weeks between committee action and floor adoption on June 27, i.e., the period that encompasses the debates on both the House and Senate floors. (3) The period of conference deliberations, from June 27 until two weeks before the final action in each chamber on the conference report. And (4) the final two weeks leading up to each chamber's vote on the conference report in late November. The data thus organized, we can test whether groups' issue ad targeting strategies change when inside objectives change as a bill moves through a multistage process.

To measure the issue's potential salience in the state, we use two terms. The first is the per capita number of prescriptions filled by Medicare-age recipients in the state.[12] The second is the number of organization sites per district that group *i* has in state *j*, where site refers to any office, chapter, plant, or other facility with a distinct address.[13] The more sites a group has in a state, we assume, the more numerous will be its members/employees and leaders (owners, managers, patrons, or other "superconstituents") likely to be attentive to issues affecting the group.

The number of organization sites should tap support for the group's position as well as the issue's salience, but to measure popular support more generally, we use the 2000 National Annenberg Election Survey (hereafter, NAES), which asked respondents specifically whether they supported a Clinton administration proposal to add reimbursable prescription drug coverage to Medicare (National Annenberg Election Survey 2000). Conveniently, all five groups took strong positions on this proposal at the time. This survey has the added advantage of being conducted prior to the emergence of the issue advertising we analyze, and it included respectable state-level samples, ranging from 62 for Delaware to 2,387 for California. To capture the popularity of the group's position, we use the state proportion supporting Medicare prescription drug coverage for the groups that supported the Clinton proposal, transformed to a 0 to 1 scale. We take one minus that value for groups that opposed the proposal.[14]

Our second category of independent variables concerns the member attributes that we think most important to a group's targeting decisions, namely, its perception of the legislator's ex ante tendency to agree with or be undecided about its policy objectives. To measure the group's perception of prior position, we use a measure that interest groups themselves construct for this purpose (Fowler 1982)—a roll call scorecard. We use the liberal American Public Health Association's (APHA) voting index from the previous congress. For all groups, we classified as likely "undecideds" or swing voters the members in the 20-percentile interval of APHA voting scores centered on the respective chamber pivots (Krehbiel 1998)—the median member in the House and the 60th or filibuster pivot in the Senate.[15] For groups supporting the administration bill, we classify legislators as likely "allies" if their score is outside the APHA pivot interval on the low side; for the group opposing the bill, "allies" are those with scores outside that interval on the high side.[16]

To characterize a state's congressional delegation, we use the percentage of delegation members that fell into each category—ally and swing, respectively—relative to group *j*'s position, separately subsetting those who did and did not sit on one of the committees of jurisdiction. This gives us for both committee members and nonmembers (1) the percentage of the delegation for state *i* that is predisposed to agree with group *j* on health issues, and (2) the percentage of the delegation for state *i* that are likely swing voters. The excluded category in our analysis is thus the percentage of a delegation's members that were likely opponents of group *j*. Because the bill was high on the Bush Administration's agenda and pushed aggressively by Republican leaders in both chambers, party composition of the delegation should also indicate support for the bill. The high collinearity

[12]These data come from a 2003 survey, "Kaiser/Commonwealth/Tufts-New England Medical Center National Survey of Seniors and Prescription Drugs."

[13]Sites were identified using the *Mergent Online* database for firms and the *Guidestar* database for nonprofits and checked against the groups' websites for 2003.

[14]The ARA and the AARP supported the Clinton proposal; the other three groups vehemently opposed it because of its single-payer financing mechanism.

[15]We use the 20% interval rather than, say 33%, because it captures those likely to be pivotal more cleanly, given the bimodal distribution of congressional voting. The filibuster pivot in the Senate was the 60th on the APHA scale.

[16]Consistent with our use of its voting score, the APHA opposed the Medicare prescription drug bill in 2003.

TABLE 1 Issue Advertising on the Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003: Distribution by Group

	State-Level Ads			District-Level Ads		
	States Covered	State Mean	State Maximum	Districts w/ Ads	District Mean	District Maximum
AARP	46	318.8	916 (FL)	-	-	-
Alliance to Improve Medicare	13	37.7	249 (IN)	-	-	-
Alliance for Retired Americans	12	17.8	81 (WA)	-	-	-
Pfizer, Inc.	7	3.3	38 (PA)	-	-	-
United Seniors Association	45	718.7	2545 (KY)	356	276.2	1803

Source: Wisconsin Advertising Project (http://wiscadproject.wise.edu/)
Note: Ads that spanned more than one state or district counted as ads in each state/district. See discussion in text.

between Republican party and prior APHA voting score (r = -.95 in the House, r = -.91 in the Senate) makes them difficult to disentangle, however. For our purposes, party has the added disadvantage in that it does not help us identify which members in the delegation might be swing voters. We nonetheless include party composition in the main analysis, with little consequence for the results, but omit it from the stage-by-stage analysis where the variance is more difficult to parse.

Based on the theoretical discussion above, several additional variables require specification. We measure the presence of electoral vulnerability as the percentage of the state delegation that is electorally insecure, defined as whether the delegation member won with a margin less than 10 points in the last election. We also control for two factors likely to affect the geographic incidence of state issue ads related to the overlapping nature of media market boundaries: (1) whether a state has a major media market that includes metropolitan areas in contiguous states, such that it tends to receive significant spillover advertising; and (2) whether the state overlaps the Washington, DC media market, in which issue ads are unusually concentrated, presumably to affect actors inside the Beltway (Falk 2003; Falk, Grizard, and McDonald 2006).

Table 1 provides descriptive statistics on the incidence of issue ads by group. Two things are noteworthy there. First, the variance across groups is high. This fact raises important questions about the role of group resources or group-party connections that might explain such variance, but given the paucity of groups in our sample and our focus on legislative targeting, such questions must remain matters for future study. In our analysis we relegate group-specific factors to group fixed effects. Second, Table 1 reveals that almost all of the issue advertising on the MMA was run by pro-bill groups. Only the ARA consistently opposed the bill, and it was fourth out of five in the number of advertisements aired. Thus are the data limited in what they can tell us about how the advertising strategies vary by side or whether advertising by one side was designed to counteract advertising by the other, as Austen-Smith and Wright find for inside lobbying (1994).

Targeted Issue Advertisements

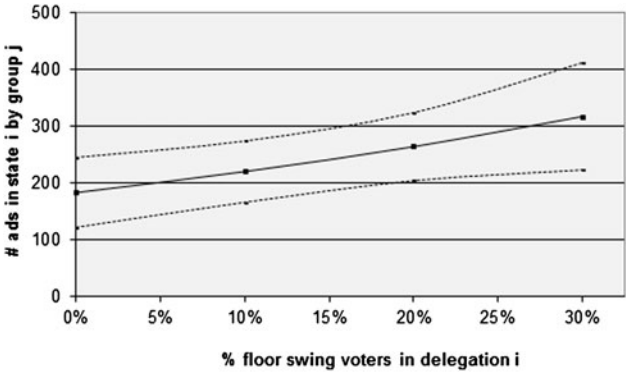
In this section we analyze the state-level incidence of issue advertisements for the entire process; in the next section we analyze the data by legislative stage. The dependent variable in Models 2.1–2.3 is the number of ads broadcast in state i by group j for 11 months in 2003, from the session's opening in January to the final votes on the conference report in late November. Because of the ad count's overdispersion and the multilevel structure of the data, we use a mixed negative binomial estimator with state random intercepts and group fixed effects. By virtue of population alone, states have different conditional propensities of ads airing within their borders. We thus adjust for exposure by including the log of state population with the coefficient set to one.

Targeting Swing Voters and Allies

Model 2.1 incorporates Goldstein's "lobby-the-middle" hypothesis with two terms: the percentage of committee members near the respective chamber pivots and the percentage of committee nonmembers near the chamber pivots.[17] Are interest groups upping their advertising buys in media markets where the presence of committee and/or floor swing voters is high? The results of the Model 2.1 provide little evidence that they do.

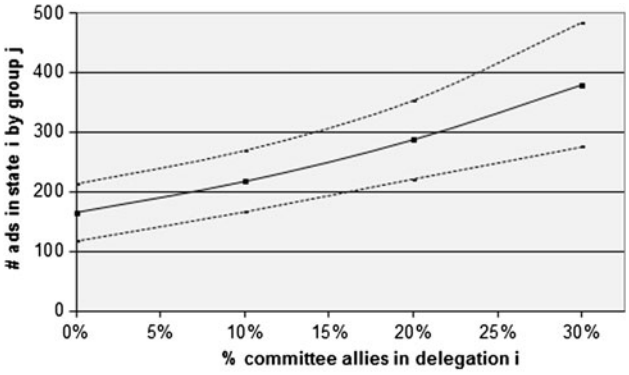
[17]Because two committees in each chamber had jurisdiction over part of the MMA, almost 90% of the state delegations had at least one committee member.

FIGURE 1a Targeting Pivotal Members: The Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003



Source: Wisconsin Advertising Project (http://wiscadproject.wisc.edu/).
Note: The predicted ad counts are generated from Model 2.3. Dotted lines represent 95% confidence upper and lower bounds.

FIGURE 1b Targeting Committee Allies: The Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003



Source: Wisconsin Advertising Project (http://wiscadproject.wisc.edu/).
Note: The predicted ad counts are generated from Model 2.3. Dotted lines represent 95% confidence upper and lower bounds.

The importance of floor swing voters to a group's advertising strategy appears larger in the analysis of Model 2.3, however, where the percentage of delegation committee and floor allies are not relegated to the intercept. Group advertising buys are increasing in the percentage of rank and file swing voters in a state delegation, with the coefficient statistically significant and over half as large as the Model 2.1 estimate. Figure 1a illustrates the substantive effect of this variable using the predicted counts of state-level issue ads. Recall that the mean number of ads aired in state *i* by group *j* is just over 200, and the distribution is overdispersed: The standard deviation is 369.6, with almost half of all observations at zero. Figure 1a shows that when the state's percentage of swing voters on the floor is zero (about one standard deviation below the sample mean), the number of ads aired in state *j* is about 130. The predicted count of ads does not reach the sample mean until the percentage of floor swing voters exceeds 25%, which is about one standard deviation above that variable's mean. Still, the variable's relationship with advertising is not trivial. A two standard deviation difference predicts an increase of almost 75% in the number of ads aired at the state level.

In showing that issue advertising buys are affected by the presence of pivotal floor voters in a state's delegation, then, Model 2.3 confirms a hypothesis set forth clearly in Goldstein (1999). However, the results do not support Goldstein's more specific conclusion that "the swing members on committee" are the major targets (58–59, Table 4.3). We found no evidence of this, regardless of specification. We do not take that to imply that lobbyists do not care about committee votes, however. Lobbyists may try to influence wavering members indirectly by inducing committee allies to lobby their undecided colleagues (Hojnacki and Kimball 1999) or to define the alternatives over which members vote. Those activities are consistent with the view that the proximate objective of direct lobbying is mobilization.

Stronger evidence of this tendency appears in Model 2.2, which assumes that outside lobbying is intended solely to mobilize sympathetic members. Do groups run ads in areas represented disproportionately by their legislative allies? The answer provided by Model 2.2 is yes, but only when those allies hold institutional positions that enable them to shape the legislation and credibly signal their colleagues regarding its merits. That effect also proves robust in Model 2.3, in which the swing-voter hypotheses are also embedded. Figure 1b uses predicted counts from Model 2.3 to represent the substantive relationship between the presence of committee allies in a state's delegation and the number of issue ads aired in that state. The slope is both positive and steeper than the slope for swing voters in Figure 1a. When there are no committee allies in a state, the predicted count of ads is 158, but that number increases by well over half when a delegation's percentage of committee allies is at the mean (14%), and it more than doubles (to 359) at one standard deviation above the mean (29%). For delegations especially high in committee allies—the top 5% or about two standard deviations above the

TABLE 2 Multilevel Negative Binomial Models of State Issue Ads: The Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003

	(1)	(2)	(3)
State Constituency Attributes			
Organization sites per Congressional district	1.55* (.52)	1.69* (.51)	1.46* (.52)
Per capita number of prescription among Medicare recipients	.04* (.02)	.04* (.01)	.03* (.02)
Percentage of survey respondents agreeing with group on Medicare Rx	.80 (.61)	1.09* (.53)	.94 (.55)
State Delegation Attributes			
Percentage swing members, on committee	-.02 (1.15)		.29 (.99)
Percentage swing members, noncommittee	1.20 (.73)		1.79* (.77)
Percentage allies, on committee		2.13* (.62)	2.59* (.67)
Percentage allies, not on committee		-.05 (.53)	.51 (.59)
Percentage Republican (Majority)	1.20* (.46)	.46 (.59)	.34 (.59)
Percentage from marginal seats	2.44* (.89)	2.54* (.78)	2.38* (.79)
Media Market Controls			
State borders DC media market	.76* (.29)	.88* (.27)	.80* (.28)
State borders metro media market	.13 (.18)	.14 (.18)	.10 (.18)
Constant	-3.20* (.51)	-2.98* (.45)	-3.13* (.46)
Wald chi-sq =	449.49	474.34	477.12
Prob > chi2 =	.000	.000	.000

*$p < .05$, two-tailed; n of obs. = 230.
Sources: Kaiser Family Foundation, "Kaiser/Commonwealth/Tufts-New England Medical Center 2003 National Survey of Seniors and Prescription Drugs" (http://www.kff.org/medicine/med041905pkg.cfm); American Public Health Association's *Annual Vote Tallies, Almanac of American Politics 2004*. See discussion in text for additional variable definitions and sources.
Note: DV = # of television ads aired in state *i* by group *j*, January to November 2003. Entries are negative binomial coefficients with state random intercepts and group fixed effects (group dummies not shown), with exposure = ln(state population). Alaska, Hawaii, North Dakota, and South Dakota omitted due to missing data.

mean—the predicted count is almost 500 ads, over three times the number for delegations with no committee allies, of which there were many.

Salience, Public Support, and Electoral Vulnerability

Likewise embedded in the equations estimated for Table 2 are the two main hypotheses set out in Kollman (1998), namely, that groups will outside lobby to the extent that an issue is (or might become) salient and the extent to which the group's position on the issue is popular. The analysis provides evidence for both propositions. The potential salience of the Medicare prescription drug issue is captured by the first two variables in Table 2, both of which have statistically significant and substantively nontrivial effects. A state where the number of organizational sites is one standard deviation above the mean saw 44% more ads than states with no sites. The per capita prescriptions filled by Medicare recipients has a coincidentally similar effect: Television audiences in a state where seniors' prescription levels were one standard deviation above the sample mean saw about 90 more ads than viewers in a state with prescriptions one standard deviation below it, a difference of 45%.

The second constituency factor Kollman emphasizes is the current or likely popularity of a group's policy. Unless they expect that their issue ads will be widely persuasive, interest groups will be less likely to make expensive advertising buys in areas where the priors of the audience run contrary to the group's message. Taken as a whole, the evidence also supports this hypothesis. As we note above, the number of sites per district should tap both support for the organization's policies as well as salience, and again, that effect is statistically significant and substantial. However, the Annenberg survey measure of public support for expanding Medicare as a single payer to cover prescription drugs provides a more general measure. That the survey occurred in 2000 is an advantage insofar as we avoid picking up any endogenous effect of issue advertising, but because it was well prior to the 2003 debate, it is no doubt noisier than the information on which the interest group strategist would have relied. As the results of Model 2.3 show, the relationship between public support for the group's position and the incidence of advertising is correct in sign but statistically significant only at the .10 level. However,

TABLE 3 Multilevel Negative Binomial Models of State Issue Ads by Legislative Stage: The Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003

	(1) Committee Stage	(2) Floor Action	(3) Conference Stage	(4) Final Action
State Constituency Attributes				
Organization sites per Congressional district	2.02* (.57)	2.05* (.67)	1.72* (.57)	1.71* (.51)
Per capita number of prescriptions among Medicare recipients	.04* (.02)	.03 (.02)	.03 (.02)	.02 (.02)
Percentage of survey respondents agreeing with group on Medicare Rx	.17* (.06)	.20* (.06)	.02* (.00)	.07 (.05)
State Delegation Attributes				
Percentage swing members, on committee	-2.25* (1.13)	.93 (1.36)	.27 (1.29)	.08 (1.05)
Percentage swing members, noncommittee	1.58 (.84)	4.72* (1.12)	2.91* (1.01)	1.19 (.80)
Percentage allies, on committee	2.35* (.69)	4.24* (.74)	3.60* (.68)	2.60* (.58)
Percentage allies, not on committee	.95 (.51)	1.13 (.71)	.96 (.64)	.89 (.48)
Percentage from marginal seats	1.97* (.87)	1.49 (1.19)	2.56* (.97)	2.38* (.80)
Media Market Controls				
State borders DC media market borders	.66* (.29)	.15 (.44)	.47 (.39)	.81* (.32)
State borders metro media market	.31 (.18)	.16 (.24)	.25 (.23)	-.11 (.19)
Constant	-3.84* (.77)	-4.84* (1.01)	-6.00* (.96)	-4.08* (.70)
Wald chi-sq	216.24	110.22	203.96	262.75
Prob > chi2 =	.000	.000	.000	.000

*$p < .05$, two-tailed; n of observations = 230.
Sources: Kaiser Family Foundation, "Kaiser/Commonwealth/Tufts-New England Medical Center 2003 National Survey of Seniors and Prescription Drugs" (http://www.kff.org/medicare/med041905pkg.cfm); American Public Health Association's *Annual Vote Tallies, Almanac of American Politics 2004*. See discussion in text for additional variable definitions and sources.
Note: Dependent variable = # of television ads aired in state *i* by group *j* for the specified period. Entries are negative binomial coefficients with state random intercepts and group fixed effects (group dummies not shown), with exposure term = ln(state population of i). Alaska, Hawaii, North Dakota, and South Dakota omitted due to missing data.

the predicted count of ads broadcast in states with high public support (one standard deviation above the mean) is approximately 54% higher than the number in low support states (one standard deviation below).

Finally, the results reported in Table 2 provide consistent support for the hypothesis that groups target their advertisements in states of members whose electoral vulnerability should make them especially sensitive to grassroots activity. States with relatively high percentages of vulnerable members (one standard deviation above the sample mean, about 30%) in their delegation witnessed 44% more ads than those that had none.

Issue Advertising by Legislative Stage

If outside advertising is driven by inside ends, a group's advertising targets should change as the key players change in a sequential legislative process. Committee allies should remain important throughout the process, first as decision makers and later as coalition builders and cue givers. Legislators near the chamber's pivot, in contrast, should warrant little attention early in the process, greater attention as closely contested roll calls approach. We explore these hypotheses by reestimating Model 2.3 for four separate intervals: Model 3.1 analyzes ads that appeared during committee consideration, i.e., the period from bill introduction to the beginning of floor action; Model 3.2 analyzes ads broadcast during the two weeks of floor debate after the committee report, ending in floor votes on adoption in late June 2003; Model 3.3 analyzes the conference period, i.e., the 15 weeks from the June floor vote to the conference report; and Model 3.4 examines ads during the endgame, the two weeks between the conference report and final adoption.[18]

The results reported in Table 3 support the hypotheses that groups will target committee allies

[18]For reasons noted above, we omit the party composition of the delegation from the stage-by-stage analysis. Including it changes the results for only the first of the four periods, where Republican percentage but not percentage allies is statistically significant. Only groups supporting the administration bill advertised in that period, making those two variables difficult to distinguish.

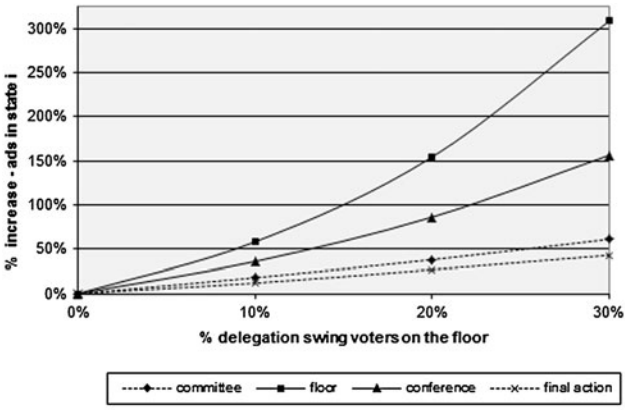
and that they will do so throughout the process. The coefficient on percentage committee allies in a delegation proves statistically significant in the equations for all four stages, and the substantive effects are roughly similar across stages. Varying the percentage committee allies from zero, which is about one standard deviation below the mean, to 30%, which is about one standard deviation above the mean, increases the ad count *ij* for each period by 50 ads, plus or minus 15. Because the stages were of different durations and thus witnessed advertising on different scales, however, the better comparison is the percent change in the predicted ad counts. In each period, varying percent committee allies from zero to 30% more than doubles the number of spots aired by group *j* in state *i*, and at the critical floor stage (Period 2), it triples that number.

In this respect, our results are again inconsistent with Goldstein, who argues that outside lobbying at the committee stage should target undecided committee members (1998, 58–60). Were that true, we should see positive coefficients for the presence of committee members near the pivot, and the effects should be greater than for the presence of committee or floor allies. However, the presence of committee swing members in the delegation has a negative effect, sharply so, not positive. In the remaining periods, the incidence of committee swing voters has a negligible effect.

The main hypothesis we take from earlier work, however, is that outside lobbying will target members that are near the chamber pivot, i.e., rank and file "swing" legislators who are thus likely to be undecided. Above we complicate that claim theoretically by arguing that the value of such targets will depend on the legislative stage, namely, moments when floor votes are approaching and are likely to be close. In the MMA case, those conditions clearly held in Periods 2 and 4. The former is the period of initial floor debate: the two weeks between committee action and the floor votes on passage in the respective chambers. The House bill would pass by a single vote. The Senate bill would pass the same day by a substantial margin, but only after close votes occurred on multiple amendments and an obstructionist motion fell short by two.

As hypothesized, the geographic deployment of issue ads shifted as the floor vote on initial passage approached. Statistically insignificant in Period 1, the swing voter coefficient in Period 2 (Model 3.2) is positive and statistically significant. That effect is substantively large as well. Figure 2 captures the stage-varying magnitude of the swing voter effects. The lines represent for each stage the percentage change in predicted ads aired by group *j* as the percentage of swing voters in delegation *i* varies from zero to 30%—approximately one standard deviation below the sample mean to one standard deviation above it.[19] The effect for the floor stage is represented by the solid, square-studded line. A change from zero to 30% in the incidence of committee allies in state delegation *i* generates a 305% increase in the number of issue ads run in that state by group *j*.

FIGURE 2 Issue Advertising by Legislative Stage: Targeting Swing Voters on the MMA of 2003



Source: Wisconsin Advertising Project (http://wiscadproject.wisc.edu/).
Note: The predicted ad counts are based on Models 3.1-3.4.

However, we see no similar targeting of swing members in Period 4 (Model 3.4), the two weeks leading up to the final November votes on the conference report. The x-studded line (dotted because the effect is statistically insignificant) is the flattest of the four. Groups did not do much to shift their advertising dollars near the very end of the process to areas represented by near-pivotal members, as they had in mid-June. This result is surprising in that the votes on the conference report in November were at least as close in both the House and Senate as they had been on initial passage.[20] No doubt one reason for this result is that by the time of the late November vote, most members had taken public positions on their respective chambers' bills and on most of its highly contested provisions. The June floor debate in the Senate included votes on more than 150 amendments,

[19]The mean and standard deviation for percent committee allies in delegation *i* are .14 and .16, respectively. The comparable statistics are .17 and .14 for the percent floor swing voters.

[20]The bill would have failed, had the GOP leadership not kept the vote open for an unprecedented three hours (Dewar and Goldstein 2003).

TABLE 4 Negative Binomial Models of District Issue Ads: The United Seniors Association and the Medicare Prescription Drug Bill of 2003

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Constituency Attributes			
Percent of district population over 65	-.93 (1.23)	-1.42 (1.22)	-1.49 (1.24)
Percentage of survey respondents agreeing with group on Medicare Rx	2.83 (1.90)	2.84 (1.82)	2.86 (1.83)
House Member Attributes			
Committee member	0.18 (.12)	-.08 (.20)	-.10 (.20)
Proximity to APHA median	0.30 (.27)		0.26 (.27)
Proximity to median X Cmte. member	.78 (.66)		0.71 (.65)
Group support score (1-APHA index)		0.34* (.13)	0.34* (.13)
Group support score X committee member		0.53* (.26)	0.54* (.27)
Won last election by fewer than 10 points	0.75* (.27)	0.77* (.26)	0.78* (.26)
Media Market Controls			
District borders DC market	1.01* (.26)	0.99* (.25)	0.99* (.25)
Constant	-1.50* (.70)	-1.57* (.68)	-1.58* (.69)
Wald chi-sq =	36.46	56.21	59.32
Prob > chi2 =	.000	.000	.000

*$p < .05$, two-tailed; n of obs = 430.
Sources: Kaiser Family Foundation, "Kaiser/Commonwealth/Tufts-New England Medical Center 2003 National Survey of Seniors and Prescription Drugs" (http://www.kff.org/medicare/med041905pkg.cfm); American Public Health Association's *Annual Vote Tallies, Almanac of American Politics 2004*. See discussion in text for additional variable definitions and sources.
Note: Dependent variable = # of television ads aired in state *i* by group *j* by the United Seniors Association. Entries are negative binomial coefficients with state random intercepts. Five districts omitted due to missing data. Exposure term = ln(% of district covered by 100 top DMAs).

35 by roll-call vote. The House floor action in June of 2003 was controlled by a closed rule that permitted no amendments, but soon thereafter the House considered a number of specific provisions on the floor in the form of motions to instruct the conferees. Over the period late-July to mid-November, the House voted on 20 motions to instruct, fifteen of which were decided by roll calls, three of them by very close margins. Although closely contested motions to instruct are not common in the House, their frequency in this case helps make sense of the relatively high, statistically significant level of advertising focused on swing voters during Period 3. In Figure 2, this effect is represented by the solid, diamond-studded line. Varying the presence of swing voters in a delegation from one standard deviation below to one above the sample mean increases the predicted number of issue ads in the conference period by 150%.

Targeting House Members: Advertising by the United Seniors Association

The examination of targeting thus far has focused on the relationship between the composition of state delegations and the incidence of issue advertising, most of which consists of generic rather than member- or chamber-specific appeals. That analysis assumes that inside lobbyists develop targeting strategies based on individual member attributes, but their optimal outside advertising buys weigh the variable targeting value of all members that share a political geography. Insofar as this assumption is incorrect, however, we may be aggregating the data in a way that the advertising strategists do not, thus risking ecological inference bias.

In this section we thus shift our analysis to the level of the individual House member, analyzing data on district-level advertisements by the only group to run House-specific ads, the United Seniors Association. USA was one of the two top issue advertisers on the MMA, making ad buys that spanned two-thirds of the states and over 80% of House districts. Although we can determine in the data the ads that targeted individual House members, the coding does not reliably identify *which* member.[21] We thus

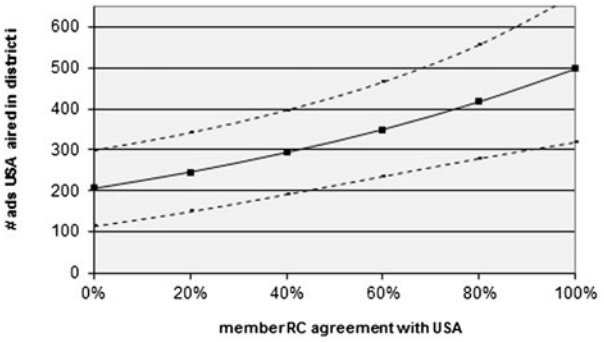
[21]The unreliability of the member identifier arises because the same storyboard was sometimes used for different members with only the name changed, a change that the coding did not consistently capture.

assigned member-specific ads to individual districts if the DMA included that district.

Table 4 translates the specifications used in the state-level analyses of Table 2 to the analysis of district-level advertising by United Seniors.[22] The main independent variables are district- and member-specific attributes rather than state- and delegation-level attributes. The indicator of past agreement with the conservative United Seniors Association is one minus the House member's APHA score, operationalized as before. The swing voter measure is the proximity of the member's APHA score to the House median. Likewise both variables are interacted with committee membership. There is no measure of prescription drug use by seniors at the district level, so we substitute the percentage of the district's population age 65 or greater. We use one minus the state-level measure of public support in 2000 for direct Medicare payment for prescription drugs, a proposal that the pharmaceutical industry-funded USA vehemently opposed. In 2003, the United Seniors had no organizational sites other than its DC-area headquarters, so that term drops out. Party is highly collinear with the APHA-based agreement measure ($r = .95$) so we omit it.[23]

Analogous to the respective models in Table 2, Model 4.1 assumes that issue advertising is essentially a strategy for bringing pressure to bear on pivotal legislators. Model 4.2 assumes that it is a strategy for mobilizing allies. Model 4.3 incorporates both hypotheses in a head-to-head test. The effects of constituency support and salience are not borne out by this analysis, nor do we find evidence of targeting swing voters among the House rank and file. The effects for proximity to the House median (Models 4.1 and 4.3) and its interaction with committee position are positive, but both coefficients in both specifications are statistically insignificant, even at generous thresholds (e.g., $p > .25$). Of course, such effects may be masked in this analysis by the fact that we cannot parse the ads of this one group by legislative stage. Still, one of the peculiarities of this case is that because of repeated attempts to instruct the conferees, significant floor votes occurred in the House on the prescription drug bill every month in 2003, save August, from the committee report in June to the bill's final adoption in late November.

FIGURE 3 Targeting House Committee Allies: Issue Advertising by the United Seniors Association



Source: Wisconsin Advertising Project (http://wiscadproject.wisc.edu/).

Note: The predicted ad counts are generated from Model 4.3. Dotted lines represent 95% confidence upper and lower bounds. Squares indicate committee members.

The mobilization hypotheses, in contrast, receive the strong support in the district-level analysis. The number of USA issue ads aired in a district is increasing in the conservatism of the representative's past voting on health issues, and this effect is magnified for members who sat on one of the two House committees with jurisdiction over the MMA. Figure 4 illustrates the combined effects in the same manner as above. We plot the predicted counts of ads against the representative's level of past voting with the conservative USA, setting committee membership at one and the proximity to median effect at zero. We plot the full range of agreement because so many members were at the two poles, with 17% having a USA relative agreement score of zero (APHA=1.00) and 26% having an agreement score of 100% (APHA=0). As Figure 4 shows, being a perfect committee ally increases the number of USA's district-level ads by a factor of 2.5. This result parallels the delegation level effect shown in Figure 1b, thus providing some reassurance that those results were not artifacts of aggregation bias.

Conclusion

Over the last several decades, the business of grassroots mobilization has become highly professionalized (Walker 2009). Hundreds of consultants now sell their savvy to firms, unions, trade associations, public interest groups, and other political organizations, advising them

[22]Districts have roughly equal populations, but they are not equally well covered by the top 100 markets. To adjust for the resulting inequalities in the unconditional propensities of ads airing in particular districts, we include the log of an exposure term—the estimated percent of the district's population covered by the DMAs in our data—with the coefficient constrained to 1.

[23]Including it only increases the effect of group agreement with the member and the effect of the agreement-committee membership interaction.

on how to mobilize some citizens and not others to participate in politics between elections. A substantial and growing share of that money goes to television issue advertising.

Nonetheless we know very little about the use of paid advertising in interest group advocacy. This article begins to fill the gap by providing a systematic analysis of where, when, and why interest groups use issue advertising to achieve their legislative objectives. For the most part, our analysis of television issue advertising on the 2003 Medicare prescription drug bill confirms basic propositions drawn from the literature on outside lobbying, namely, that interest groups will target their issue advertising buys in areas where an issue is likely to be salient, where voters are sympathetic to the group's policy views, and where incumbent legislators are electorally vulnerable.

At the same time, we revisit the assumptions about inside lobbying on which theorizing about outside lobbying depends. As others have argued, inside lobbying is not only an exercise in winning roll-call votes; it also involves mobilizing legislators who already agree with the group. Outside lobbying, in turn, can support either purpose. By bringing constituent opinion to bear, it might change the positions taken by wavering or otherwise pivotal members. By making an issue more salient to the constituents of influential legislative allies, it gives those allies greater reason to engage in the legislative activities that make their credit claiming back home credible. Thus will legislators act in ways consistent with an interest group's objectives in Washington because their minds are focused on newly attentive constituents back home.

The two ends—persuading undecided members and mobilizing allies—are not equally well-served by outside advertising, however. Our analysis of issue advertising on the Medicare prescription drug bill shows that issue advertisers primarily targeted areas represented by legislators they should most want to mobilize—allies that sat on the relevant committees. Our analysis also provides some evidence that outside strategies change as inside strategy changes. When legislative action shifted from committee to the floor, groups expanded their TV ad buys in states disproportionately represented by members near the chamber pivot. They did so much less in the weeks preceding the final votes on the conference report, however, a result that may reflect the paucity of legislators who were uncommitted at that late stage.

This article is a first attempt to analyze issue advertising decisions outside the Washington beltway, so any conclusions one draws from it must be tentative. That media markets and television stations do not map neatly into congressional geography makes for inefficiency in interest group targeting, and it produces imprecision in our tests. To the extent that groups employ "micro-targeting" (e.g., Ridout 2009), the DMAs will be even less precise. That we nonetheless find evidence for our main hypotheses is encouraging, but the scope of the analysis limits our ability to sustain general claims. The MMA is only one case, and it is typical of all cases in that it is atypical in some ways that we cannot know. In retrospect, it appears that the MMA debate occurred at a time when television issue advertising, while already common, would soon witness explosive growth and take more sophisticated forms. We thus have much more to learn about where, when, and why advocacy groups invest in issue advertising, especially in highly competitive contexts. When we do, we should be better able to answer closely related questions about whether issue advertising matters in the legislative decision making it is intended to affect.

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